

A PRACTICAL HANDBOOK

The Guild *Translation* Handbook

دليل الترجمة

من الإنجليزية إلى العربية ومن العربية إلى الإنجليزية

English



العربية

Meaning first. Form follows.

المعنى أولاً، ثم البناء

I
Foundations

II
Methods

III
Tools

IV
Practice

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to use this handbook

كيف تستخدم هذا الدليل

This handbook is a working companion for translating between English and Arabic, in both directions. It was prepared for Guild Season workshops, where our Translation Team uses it with students on real texts.

THE THREE DOTS

The three dots of the Guild mark stand for the three phases every translation in this book goes through. Each phase has its own part of the handbook and its own checklist.

1 · ANALYSE

Read the text, its author, audience and purpose before writing a word. Ch. 14–15

2 · TRANSLATE

Choose a type, procedure or strategy for each problem you meet. Ch. 6–10

3 · COMMENT

Justify your choices, revise, and check the risks. Ch. 16–17

HOW EACH CHAPTER IS BUILT

- A **Key terms** box opens every chapter, with each term defined and given its Arabic equivalent. Every one of these terms also appears in the Glossary (p. 38).
- Examples appear in pairs. The source text is on the left and the translation on the right, with the direction marked.
- Chapters are short on purpose. Read one, then practise (pp. 35–37).

SYMBOLS

EN → AR English source, Arabic translation

✓ **Good** an accepted rendering

AR → EN Arabic source, English translation

✗ **Poor** a rendering to avoid

ABBREVIATIONS

Abbr.	Meaning	بالعربية	Abbr.	Meaning
SL	Source language	اللغة المصدر	MT	Machine translation
TL	Target language	اللغة الهدف	NMT	Neural machine translation
ST	Source text	النص المصدر	LLM	Large language model
TT	Target text	النص الهدف	PE	Post-editing
SLC	Source-language culture	ثقافة اللغة المصدر	CAT	Computer-assisted translation
TLC	Target-language culture	ثقافة اللغة الهدف	TM / TB	Translation memory / termbase
TS	Translation Studies	علم الترجمة	CDA	Critical discourse analysis
MSA	Modern Standard Arabic	العربية الفصحى المعاصرة	SVO / VSO	Subject-verb-object / verb-subject-object

What's inside

•	How to use this handbook · Abbreviations	كيف نستخدم الدليل	2
•	Before you translate: tips, techniques and preparation	نصائح وتقنيات وإعداد	4
PART I Foundations			
الأسس			
01	Translation, communication and the translator	الترجمة والتواصل والمترجم	5
02	English and Arabic compared	مقارنة بين الإنجليزية والعربية	7
03	Form, meaning and context	البناء والمعنى والسياق	9
04	Collocations and idioms	التلازم اللفظي والتعابير الاصطلاحية	11
05	Equivalence	التكافؤ	13
PART II Methods			
المناهج			
06	Types of translation	أنواع الترجمة	14
07	Seven procedures and beyond	إجراءات الترجمة السبعة	16
08	Translation strategies and metaphor	استراتيجيات الترجمة والاستعارة	18
09	Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	20
10	Descriptive translation and lexical creation	الترجمة الوصفية والتحت المعجمي	22
PART III Tools			
الأدوات			
11	Terminology management	إدارة المصطلحات	24
12	Printed and digital dictionaries	المعاجم المطبوعة والرقمية	25
13	Machine translation and AI	الترجمة الآلية والذكاء الاصطناعي	26
PART IV Practice			
التطبيق			
14	Text analysis and genres	تحليل النصوص وأجناسها	28
15	Critical discourse analysis: Fairclough's model	التحليل النقدي للخطاب	30
16	Translation commentary	التعليق على الترجمة	31
17	Interlingual risk assessment	تقييم المخاطر بين اللغتين	32
•	Practical checklists	قوائم التحقق	33
•	Common grammatical and stylistic mistakes	أخطاء نحوية وأسلوبية شائعة	34
•	Exercises at three levels · Answer key	تمارين بثلاثة مستويات	35
BACK MATTER			
الملاحق			
•	Glossary of terms	مسرد المصطلحات	38
•	References · Future editions	المراجع · الإصدارات القادمة	39

● ● ● TIPS • TECHNIQUES • PREPARATION

Before you translate

نصائح وتقنيات وإعداد للترجمة

Most translation mistakes begin before the first sentence is written, when a translator starts without knowing who the text is for. Answer three questions first. Together they make up your **translation brief** (Nord 1997).

Who is the client?

من هو العميل؟

Who commissioned the work, and what are their house style, policy and ideology? A news agency, a court and a ministry each expect different things.

What is the purpose?

ما الغرض التواصل؟

Will the text inform, persuade, instruct, bind legally or entertain? The purpose decides how far you may move away from the form.

Who is the audience?

من هو الجمهور المستهدف؟

Experts or the public? Gulf readers or pan-Arab readers? Adults or children? Pitch your terms, register and explanations to match.

Preparation

- 1 **Read the whole text twice** before you translate. Each reading brings out new ideas.
- 2 **Mark the hard parts:** unfamiliar terms, idioms, names, figures and cultural references.
- 3 **Research the field.** Read a parallel text written in the TL on the same topic.
- 4 **Build a mini-glossary** before drafting (Ch. 11), and prepare your dictionaries (Ch. 12).
- 5 **Plan your time**, with at least one pause between drafting and revising.

Working habits

- **Fidelity** (الأمانة): be faithful to the meaning, not to the words.
- **Aim for three qualities:** faithful, accurate and acceptable to TL readers.
- **Translation is rewriting.** The TT has to read as though it were written in the TL.
- **Revise every time**, even your best work. Read the TT once without the ST.
- **Translate captions, titles and footnotes too.** Nothing is "too small" to check.
- **Quality + speed = productivity.** Speed that costs quality is not productivity.

- **Guid tip.** Translation is often compared to a minefield (الترجمة حقل ألغام). A single wrong word, such as a politically loaded place name or a false friend in a contract, can harm your client and your reputation. When in doubt, look it up, ask, or flag it. Never guess.

PART I · FOUNDATIONS

01 Translation, communication and the translator

الترجمة والتواصل والمترجم

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Translation الترجمة التحريرية

Transferring the meaning of a written text from one language into another.

Interpretation الترجمة الشفهية

Transferring spoken language into another language orally, either consecutively or simultaneously.

Translation Studies علم الترجمة

The academic discipline that studies translation as a process, a product and a social practice.

Communication التواصل

To understand and to be understood: a sender passes a message to a receiver through a channel.

Four ways to define translation

Translation is...	What it means for you
Transfer of meaning	We carry the <i>textual meaning</i> across, not the words. Meaning comes before form (Ch. 3).
Interlingual communication	Translation lets people who share no language communicate. If the reader does not understand, the translation has failed.
A search for equivalence	We look for equivalence between two languages at several levels: word, phrase, text and function (Ch. 5).
Approximation	No two languages match exactly, so we bring the SL meaning <i>as close as possible</i> to the TL reader, especially its cultural meaning (Ch. 9).

Three kinds of translation

أنواع الترجمة عند ياكوبسون

Jakobson (1959) distinguishes three kinds of translation. This handbook is about the second.

INTRALINGUAL

Rewording within one language, as in paraphrasing a legal clause in plain English. **ضمن اللغة الواحدة**

INTERLINGUAL

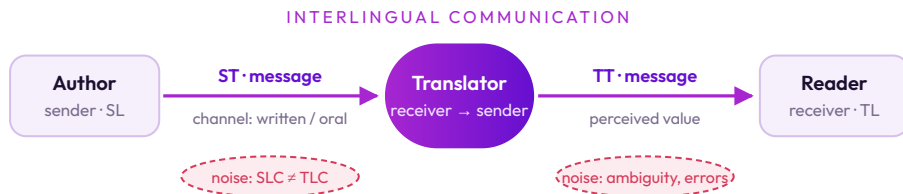
Translation proper: from one language into another, for example English into Arabic. **بين لغتين**

INTERSEMIOTIC

From words into another sign system, as when a novel becomes a film or a poem becomes a painting. **بين نظامين علاميين**

The translator inside the communication chain

In ordinary communication, a **sender** passes a **message** through a **channel** (written or oral) to a **receiver**. **Noise** is anything that distorts the message. **Perceived value** is what the receiver actually takes from it. In translation, the chain doubles: the translator is first the *receiver* of the ST and then the *sender* of the TT.



Two kinds of translator

Commissioned translator مترجم بتكليف	Self-initiated translator مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية
A client asks you to translate. You work within the client's policy, house style and ideology .	You are your own boss. You choose the text, and you answer for your own choices.

Why the client matters. The same term can be rendered in different ways depending on the editorial policy of the institution that commissions the translation. Examples:

suicide bomber

→

انتحاري / استشهادي

The choice between these two renderings reflects the commissioning outlet's editorial stance, not a language rule.

the Persian Gulf

→

الخليج العربي / الخليج الفارسي

Place names carry political weight. Follow the client's style guide and flag the issue in your commentary.

The translator's profile

- **Bilingual:** fluent in both the SL and the TL, with a wide **linguistic repertoire** (الخصيلة اللغوية) and a rich **mental lexicon**.
- **Bicultural:** cultural knowledge that matches linguistic knowledge.
- **Master of idiomaticity and phraseology** (Ch. 4).
- **A walking encyclopedia:** broad general knowledge, and familiarity with the topic of every text.
- **Experienced:** skill that grows only with practice and revision.
- **Skilled with tools:** dictionaries, termbases and MT (Part III).

02 English and Arabic compared

مقارنة بين الإنجليزية والعربية

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Derivational language لغة اشتقاقية

A language that builds words from roots and patterns. Arabic is one: from ك-ت-ب come كاتب، مكتوب، مكتبة. English relies more on compounding and affixes (*bookshop, writer*).

Verbal / nominal sentence جملة فعلية / اسمية

An Arabic sentence that starts with a verb (VSO) or with a noun. English is typically SVO.

Register المستوى اللغوي

The level of formality chosen for a situation, from formal to informal.

Diglossia الازدواجية اللغوية

Two varieties of one language used side by side for different functions, such as MSA and a spoken dialect.

Linguistic and stylistic differences

Feature	English	Arabic
Word order	SVO: <i>Sam ate the cake.</i>	VSO is the unmarked order in formal prose: أكلَ سامُ الكعكة. The nominal سامٌ أكلَ الكعكة is also grammatical, but it puts the focus on Sam.
Sentence length	Short sentences, separated by full stops.	Long sentences linked by و، ف، ثم and commas.
The verb “to be”	Always needed: <i>Translation is a field...</i>	No verb in present nominal sentences. Use يُعَدُّ / يُعْتَبَرُ when a main verb helps: تُعَدُّ الترجمة مجالاً...
Synonym pairs	Rare, and usually felt as redundant (outside legal doublets such as <i>null and void</i>).	Common for emphasis: بحرٌ هائجٌ مائجٌ شجاعٌ مغوارٌ.
Gender and number	Gender mostly on pronouns. Singular and plural only.	Gender runs through verbs, adjectives and <i>you</i> . Nouns also have a dual form.
Punctuation	Strict and rule-bound. Capital letters mark names.	Looser, with the marks ؟ ، ، . There are no capitals, so names can be ambiguous.

Three varieties of Arabic

أنواع العربية

CLASSICAL

العربية الفصحى التراثية
The language of the Qur'an and of pre-Islamic and classical poetry.

MODERN STANDARD

الفصحى المعاصرة
Used in the press, law and education. The default for written translation.

DIALECTAL

العامية / اللهجات
Everyday regional speech (Kuwaiti, Egyptian, Levantine and others). Use it only if the brief allows.

Four areas of difficulty

- 1 **Grammar** (syntax, النحو): word order, tense, agreement, the passive voice.
- 2 **Semantics** (word choice, الدلالة): collocations, connotation, false friends.
- 3 **Punctuation and style**: formal or dialect, and long or short sentences.
- 4 **General or specialised text**: specialised terms need research (Ch. 11–12).

Small words, big traps EN → AR

English	العربية	Why
<i>He is in bed.</i>	إنه نائم / طرح الفراش	This means “asleep” or “ill”, not literally “in the bed” (في السرير). Context decides.
<i>As an officer, I...</i>	بصفتي ضابطاً...	Here <i>as</i> marks a role, not a comparison: ❌ كضابط
<i>As the company's manager...</i>	بصفتي مديراً للشركة / لكوني...	The same “role” sense of <i>as</i> .
<i>Shops stay open late.</i>	تظل المحال التجارية مفتوحة...	Start with the verb. <i>Stay</i> becomes / تظل تبقى.
<i>Translation is a fascinating field.</i>	تعد الترجمة مجالاً شائقاً	<i>Is</i> as the main verb becomes تعد. Note the accusative in مجالاً.
<i>Eventually, they agreed.</i>	وافقوا في نهاية المطاف	This is not أخيراً in every context.
<i>...to see the Roman ruins</i>	لزيارة الآثار الرومانية	<i>See</i> becomes “visit”, the natural collocation in Arabic.

Caution: feminine job titles. Some feminine forms have a second meaning: قاضية can mean “a fatal blow” and نائبة “a calamity”. Some formal writers therefore prefer القاضية فلانة. Even so, القاضية and النائبة are now standard in the press and in parliament. Follow your client’s style guide.

Direction matters

EN → AR TENDS TO...

- start with the verb
- add linking words and explication
- join short sentences into longer ones

AR → EN TENDS TO...

- move the subject to the front
- cut synonym pairs and repetition
- split long sentences with full stops

PART I • FOUNDATIONS

03

Form, meaning and context

البناء والمعنى والسياق

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Form البناء

The structure that carries meaning: a word structure, compound, phrase, clause, sentence, paragraph or text.

Meaning المعنى

The content a form expresses. It is cognitive (mental and abstract), and that is why it is complex.

Denotation / المعنى الإشاري / المعجمي

The core, conceptual dictionary meaning of a word.

Connotation / المعنى الإيحائي / الضمني

The associations and shades of meaning added to the denotation: positive, negative, formal, religious, political.

The golden rule: meaning over form

Behind every form there is a meaning. You may change the form. You may not change the meaning.

Because English and Arabic build meaning with different structures, changing the form is normal. An adjective can become a verb, or a verb a noun, and so on (see *transposition*, Ch. 7).

Blair, Bush's poodle

→

بليز، ذيلُ بوش / تابعُ بوش

A poodle has no political sense in Arabic. ~~كلب بوش المدلل~~. The meaning, “an obedient follower”, is kept and the image changes.

He is a heavy smoker.

→

يدخن بشراهة

Adjective + noun becomes verb + adverbial.

Denotation and connotation

Same denotation...	...different connotations
die مات	<i>pass away</i> انتقل إلى رحمة الله (respectful) · <i>kick the bucket</i> (informal, joking) · استشهد (religious or political, positive) · نفق (used of animals, and insulting if used of people)
horse حصان	<i>steed</i> جواد (noble, positive) · <i>horse</i> (neutral) · <i>nag</i> (old or worthless, negative)
friend صديق	<i>comrade</i> رفيق (a fellow member of a party or movement)
kill قتل	<i>assassinate</i> اغتال (to kill a public figure, usually for political reasons)

MORE KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Sentence meaning	What the words literally say.
Speaker meaning	What the speaker intends by saying them.
Context السياق	Any background information that helps us understand a text.
Homonymy المشترك اللفظي	One form with several <i>unrelated</i> meanings.
Polysemy تعدد المعنى	One form with several <i>related</i> meanings.

Sentence meaning and speaker meaning

أشعرُ بالحرِّ.

→ Speaker meaning: *Please turn on the air conditioning.*

It's freezing in here.

→ Speaker meaning: أغلق النافذة / أطفئ المكيف

Keep the form wherever the TL reader can infer the same intention. Make the intention explicit only when they cannot.

Context: micro and macro

Micro context (co-text, the immediate context) is the text itself: the words and sentences around the problem.

Macro context is everything outside the text: the **author** (Shawqi, Qabbani and Darwish do not write alike), the **audience**, the **translator**, the **time and place** of writing, and the economic, social and historical circumstances.

لكلِّ مقامٍ مقال

Every communicative situation has its own context.



The translation triangle: text, author and audience, with the translator • at the centre.

Homonymy and polysemy

Homonymy: unrelated meanings

bank: ضفّة النهر · مصرف

case: حاكمة / قضية / حالة · a situation or legal matter · علبّة / حافظة · (two different Latin roots)

Polysemy: related meanings

طهّر: purifying from sin · disinfecting a wound · احتجاز: retaining water · holding hostages · بناء: a building · a structure

Note: عين (eye · spring · spy) is the classic Arabic مشترك لفظي. In every case, **the context tells you which meaning is active.**

04 Collocations and idioms

التلازم اللفظي والتعابير الاصطلاحية

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Collocation التلازم اللفظي Words that habitually occur together. In Firth's (1957) phrase, it is "the company a word keeps".

Collocational meaning The meaning a word takes on from its partner: *pay* money, but also *pay* attention.

One verb, many partners EN → AR

English	العربية	Meaning type
pay money	يدفع مالاً	Denotational
pay attention	يُنْتَبِه / يُعِير انتباهه	Collocational
pay one's respects	يُبدِي احترامه / يُقدِّم واجب العزاء	Collocational
pay a visit	يقوم بزيارة × يدفع زيارة	Collocational

One adjective, many meanings

fast...	English	العربية
a fast car	strong tea	شاي ثقيل × قوي
a fast colour	weak coffee	قهوة خفيفة
a fast friend	a rough sea	بحر هائج
fast asleep	an addled egg	بيضة فاسدة
	close cooperation · a close friend	تعاون وثيق · صديق مقرب
	a plain shirt	قميص سادة

Arabic collocations AR → EN

العربية	English	العربية	English
استل سيفه	drew his sword	لاذ اللص بالفرار	the thief fled
يساورني القلق	I am growing worried	حديقة غناء	a lush garden
قدّم استقالته	tendered his resignation	خرق القانون	broke / breached the law

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Idiom التعبير الاصطلاحي

A fixed expression of more than one word whose total meaning is *not* the sum of its words: *It's a piece of cake* means "it is easy".

Proverb المثل

A short, traditional saying that expresses a general truth or piece of advice.

- **Rule.** Never translate an idiom word for word. First check whether it is actually used as an idiom in this context: *a piece of cake* at a birthday party may simply be قطعة من الكعكة.

English idioms

EN → AR

Idiom	العربية
It's raining cats and dogs.	تمطر بغزارة / كأفواه القرب
to be over the moon	يطير من الفرح / في قمة السعادة
to pull one's socks up	شمر عن ساعديه
to spill the beans	أفشى السر
Mark my words.	تذكر كلامي جيداً
I'm all ears.	كلّي آذان صاغية
Break a leg!	بالتوفيق! ✗ اكسر ساقاً
Don't put words in my mouth.	لا تقولني ما لم أقل
It has been a long day.	كان يوماً شاقاً ✗ يوماً طويلاً

Arabic proverbs

AR → EN

كالمتجبر من الرمضاء بالنار	Out of the frying pan into the fire.
رجع بخفي حنين	He came back empty-handed.
أقلب الجرة على فيها تطلع البنت لأُمها (colloquial)	Like mother, like daughter.
لكل مقام مقال	There is a time and a place for everything.

Legal collocations

(Ch. 4 · cont)

Article 12 – Governing Law

المادة 12 – القانون الواجب التطبيق ✗ القانون الحاكم

Article (law or constitution) · clause (contract)

مادة · بند

provided that...

شرطية أن / على أن

Tautologies: same words, deeper meaning

Boys will be boys.

الولد ولد ولو صار قاضي بلد

Business is business.

الشغل شغل (colloquial) / العمل لا مجال فيه للمجاملة

PART I · FOUNDATIONS

05

Equivalence

التكافؤ

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Equivalence التكافؤ

A central notion in Translation Studies: the relationship between an ST item and the TT item that stands for it. Translation seeks equivalence at several levels (Baker 2018): word, phrase, grammar, text and pragmatics.

Formal التكافؤ الشكلي

Keeps the SL structure: passive for passive, verb for verb, image for image.

Functional التكافؤ الوظيفي

Captures the *function* of the SL expression without its form, using a TL expression that does the same job.

Ideational التكافؤ الفكري

Conveys only the basic idea, plainly, with neither the SL form nor a TL image.

Dynamic التكافؤ الدينامي

Nida's (1964) term for a TT that produces the same *effect* on its readers as the ST had on its own readers.

One sentence, three equivalents EN → AR

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then. (Farghal & Shunnaq 1999; Farghal 2012)

CLOSE TO THE SL FORM

CLOSE TO THE BARE IDEA

A · Formal

ظَلَّت الاتفاقية حرفاً ميتاً
منذ ذلك الحين

image copied; meaning unclear

B · Functional

ظَلَّت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق
منذ ذلك الحين

a TL idiom does the same job

C · Ideational

لم تُطَبَّق الاتفاقية
منذ ذلك الحين

plain sense; no image

Source	Formal	Functional	Ideational
<i>Think outside the box.</i>	فَكَّرْ خَارِجَ الصَّنَدُوقِ	فَكَّرْ بِطَرِيقَةٍ إِبداعِيَّةٍ / غَيْرِ تَقْلِيدِيَّةٍ	
<i>All is second to none in poetry.</i>	❌ عَلِيٌّ ثَانٍ لَا أَحَدَ	عَلِيٌّ لَا يُشَقُّ لَهُ غِبَارٌ فِي الشَّعْرِ	عَلِيٌّ شَاعِرٌ مُتَمَيِّزٌ

- **Which one?** Formal equivalence is not always wrong. فَكَّرْ خَارِجَ الصَّنَدُوقِ has now entered Arabic, and binding legal texts stay close to the form. Informative and persuasive texts usually need a **functional** equivalent. Use an **ideational** one when no TL image fits or the reader needs plain language. Also mind your terms: *agreement* اتفاقية is not the same as *treaty* معاهدة.

06

Types of translation

أنواع الترجمة

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Translation method منهج الترجمة

An approach applied to a *whole text*. It decides how close the TT stays to the SL or to the TL.

Semantic translation الترجمة الدلالية

Stays close to the author's meaning and style, within what the TL allows (Newmark 1988).

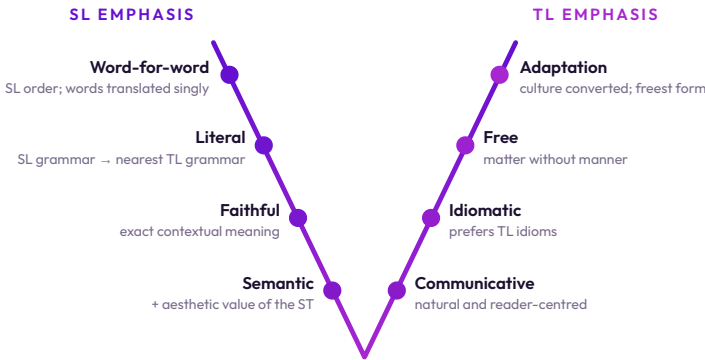
Communicative translation الترجمة التواصلية

Aims for the effect on the reader. The TT reads naturally and is easy to understand.

Adaptation الترجمة التكيفية / الاقتباس

The freest method: themes and plot are kept, and the culture is converted. It is common for plays, songs and children's books.

Newmark's V: eight methods



Newmark recommends the two methods at the base: semantic and communicative

Adapted from Newmark (1988: 45–47).

Choosing a method by text type

Text type (Reiss)	Focus	Examples	Usual method
Informative	Content	News, reports, manuals	Communicative
Expressive	Form and author	Poetry, literary prose	Semantic
Operative	Effect on the reader	Advertising, campaigns, speeches	Communicative or transcreation

Based on Reiss (1971/2000). Most real texts mix types, so identify the *dominant* one during analysis (Ch. 14).

Types by medium and purpose

Type	What it is
Written translation تحريرية	From one written text into another, e.g. legal, literary, technical, medical, media and religious texts.
Sight translation منظورة	Reading a written text aloud directly in another language, as in court or hospital settings.
Consecutive interpreting متتابعة	The speaker pauses and the interpreter renders each segment, often with notes.
Simultaneous interpreting فورية	Interpreting while the speaker talks, usually from a booth.
Audiovisual translation سمعية بصرية	Subtitling, dubbing and voice-over, with limits of time and space.
Localisation التوطين	Adapting software, websites or games to a locale: language, dates, currency, layout direction.
Transcreation الترجمة الإبداعية	Recreating advertising or branding so it has the same emotional effect in the TL.
Back-translation الترجمة العكسية	Translating a TT back into the SL to check its accuracy, as with medical questionnaires.
MT + post-editing	A human corrects machine output (Ch. 13).

Literal translation

الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة

Farghal calls it **modified literal translation**: the SL words are kept, with only the grammatical adjustments the TL needs. It can be **successful** or **destructive**.

SUCCESSFUL: A TL EQUIVALENT EXISTS

play a role → يلعب دوراً
The book is on the table. → الكتاب على الطاولة

DESTRUCTIVE: NO TL EQUIVALENT

pay a visit → يدفع زيارة يقوم بزيارة
a long day → يوم طويل يوم شاق

Context: in a bridal advertisement, *What are you wearing on your biggest day?* means ماذا سترتدين في يوم *أهم يوم لديك* ✗ is wrong here. Note the feminine verb, and زفافك؟

Free translation

الترجمة الحرة

Free translation (also called *loose translation*) keeps the message but not the manner, and it is used for all kinds of text, not only literary ones. Some scholars do not count heavily adapted texts as translations at all, only as new texts.

Source	Free rendering	Verdict
<i>Appointing new employees should be based on equal opportunity.</i>	يجب أن يتم تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة	✓ Works The same message, made local.
<i>We have had heavy rainfall this winter.</i>	سيكون لدينا موسم زراعي مبشر هذا العام	✗ Too free Adds a conclusion the ST never states.

07 Seven procedures and beyond

إجراءات الترجمة السبعة (فييني وداربلنيه)

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Direct translation الترجمة المباشرة

Used when SL elements can be carried over closely: borrowing, calque and literal translation.

Oblique translation الترجمة غير المباشرة

Used when the structures or concepts differ: transposition, modulation, equivalence and adaptation.

Vinay and Darbelnet (1958/1995) set out seven procedures, from the closest to the SL to the freest. Naming them lets you **justify** each decision in your commentary.



Method, strategy or procedure?

Term	Scope	Example
Method منهج	The whole text (Ch. 6)	Translating a news report communicatively
Strategy استراتيجية	A plan for a translation problem (Ch. 8)	Cultural substitution for an idiom
Procedure إجراء	A local technique for a word or phrase (Ch. 7)	Transposing a noun into a verb

Direct procedures

Procedure	Definition	Examples
1• Borrowing	The SL word is taken over as it is, transliterated.	computer → كمبيوتر · radio → راديو ديوانية → diwaniya · صكوك → sukuk
2• Calque	A loan translation: the parts of an SL expression are translated one by one.	skyscraper → ناطحة سحاب · shadow government → غسيل الدماغ brainwashing → حكومة الظل
3• Literal	Word-for-word translation that is still grammatical and natural in the TL.	The book is on the table. → الكتاب على الطاولة

Oblique procedures

Procedure	Definition	Examples
4 • Transposition	The word class changes but the meaning does not, e.g. noun to verb, or adjective to adverb.	<i>after his arrival</i> → بعد أن وصل <i>a heavy smoker</i> → يدخن بشراهة لدى وصوله → <i>when he arrived</i>
5 • Modulation	The point of view changes, e.g. negative to positive, passive to active, or part to whole.	<i>It is not difficult to...</i> → ...من السهل أن... <i>I don't blame you.</i> → معك حق <i>The window was broken by Ali.</i> → كسر عليُّ النافذة
6 • Equivalence	The same situation is described with a completely different expression. It is typical of idioms, proverbs and interjections.	<i>Like father, like son.</i> → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد <i>Ouch!</i> → آخ!
7 • Adaptation	An SL situation unknown in the TL culture is replaced by one that is familiar there.	<i>like Romeo and Juliet</i> → كقيس وليلى <i>a summer's day</i> (Shakespeare) → يوم ربيعي (Ch. 9)

Four procedures in one sentence EN → AR

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إن الإصلاحات ممكنة.

■ after his arrival → بعد أن وصل	Transposition: noun to verb
■ press conference → مؤتمر صحفي	Calque, now fully established
■ Sheraton → شيراتون	Borrowing (a proper name)
■ not impossible → ممكنة	Modulation: double negative to positive

Beyond the seven

إجراءات إضافية

Newmark (1988: 81–93) extends the list. Name these procedures in your commentary too (Ch. 16).

Procedure	What it does	Example
Naturalisation	A borrowing adapted to TL sounds and morphology	<i>democracy</i> → ديمقراطية
Recognised translation	The official, accepted rendering of an institutional term	<i>Security Council</i> → مجلس الأمن
Componential analysis	The word is split into its sense components and the key ones are rendered	<i>to stroll</i> → يتنقّى على مهل
Couplet	Two procedures are combined for one item	الوقف → <i>waqf</i> (a charitable endowment): borrowing + description
Translation label	A provisional rendering of a new term, in quotation marks	«التصفّح التهرّي» → <i>“doomscrolling”</i> «للأخبار السيئة»

08 Translation strategies

استراتيجيات الترجمة

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

- Strategy** استراتيجية A planned solution to a translation problem, especially when there is *no direct equivalent* (non-equivalence).
- Domestication** التوطين Bringing the text closer to TL culture so it reads as if originally written in the TL (Venuti 1995).
- Foreignisation** التغريب Keeping the foreign flavour of the ST so that the reader notices its origin.
- Compensation** التعويض Making up for a loss at one point, such as a lost pun or rhyme, with a similar effect elsewhere in the TT.

The strategy toolbox

Strategy	When to use it	Example
Functional translation	A TL expression with the same function exists.	<i>spill the beans</i> → أفشى السرّ
Cultural substitution الإبدال الثقافي	Replace a culture-specific item with a TL item that has a similar effect.	<i>like Romeo and Juliet</i> → كقيس وليلى
Addition / explicitation	Mostly EN → AR. Arabic favours elaboration (لغة إسهاب) and readers may need background.	<i>the Fed</i> → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي (البنك المركزي الأمريكي)
Omission الحذف	Mostly AR → EN: cut synonym pairs, repetition and words that add nothing. Also used, if the client agrees, to avoid offending TL readers.	شجاع مغوار → <i>very brave</i> X <i>brave and daring</i>
More general word (superordinate)	The TL lacks the specific word.	<i>prawns / shrimps</i> → روبيان
Loan word + explanation	A culture-bound term that needs to be kept.	الوقف → <i>waqf</i> (an Islamic charitable endowment)
Explanatory / descriptive الشرحية	The last resort , for cultural and technical words (Ch. 10).	الزكاة، العِدّة، الصدقة
Footnote / gloss	Explanation is needed but would break the flow of the text.	Common in literary and religious texts

FOREIGNISED

تغريب

“They spent the evening at the *diwaniya*.”
The Kuwaiti flavour is kept, and a gloss is added the first time the word appears.

DOMESTICATED

توطين

“They spent the evening at a *men’s gathering*.” The text flows smoothly, but the local colour is lost.

Baker (2018) sets out the classic strategies for non-equivalence at word level. Farghal (2012) discusses the strategies most often used between English and Arabic.

Translating metaphor

ترجمة الاستعارة

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Figurative language اللغة المجازية

Using words in a non-literal sense. It is a core concern of rhetoric (البلاغة).

Metaphor الاستعارة

A likeness stated *without* “as” or “like”: *She is a moon*. In Arabic terms: استخدام اللفظ في غير ما وضع له.

Simile التشبيه

A likeness stated *with* “as” or “like”: *She is as beautiful as the moon*.

Work down this ladder and stop at the first step that works.

1

Shared image → **reproduce it**. The first choice.

She is a snake.

→

إنها أفعى

My thoughts evaporated.

→

تجّرت أفكارى

My paper will see the light next December.

→

سترى ورقى البحثية النور في ديسمبر المقبل

2

Different image → **replace it with a TL image**.

the tip of the iceberg

→

غيضٌ من فيض / وما خفي كان أعظم

Negative contexts. For a hopeful beginning: أول الغيث قطرة

the apple of my eye

→

قرة عيني

3

Convert to a simile, keeping the image and making it explicit.

He is a rock.

→

إنه كالصخرة في ثباته

4

Reduce to the sense. The last resort, because the image is lost.

He is a chicken.

→

إنه جبان

The decision raised eyebrows.

→

أثار القرار الاستغراب

THE SAME LADDER, AR → EN

أعطاه الضوء الأخضر	gave him the green light	1 · shared
هو بحر في العلم	he is a walking encyclopedia	2 · TL image
رفع رؤوسنا	he made us proud	4 · sense



Poetry and prose. Prose leaves little room for change. Poetry allows more creative freedom, since the translator must recreate its expressive and aesthetic effect, not just its content. See the poetry exercises on p. 36.

09

Cultural approximation

التقريب الثقافي

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Approximation التقريب

Bringing the SL meaning as close as possible to the TL, since a perfect match is rare.

Cultural approximation

التقريب الثقافي

Approximating *cultural* meaning. It needs cultural knowledge of both the SLC and the TLC.

Culture-specific item عنصر

ثقافي خاص

A word, custom, institution or expression tied to one culture, with no ready counterpart in the other.

Expressions

EN → AR

English	Approximation	Note
I've got the test in the bag.	الامتحان في جيبي	Meaning: "the result is guaranteed"
They are cut from the same cloth.	هما من طينة واحدة	Cloth becomes clay
to sleep like a log	نام كالقتيل / نومة أهل الكهف	
a scapegoat	كبش الفداء	A shared religious image
Death is the great leveller.	الموت لا يفرق بين غني وفقير	كل نفس ذائقة الموت. Quote scripture with care.
Every Jack has his Jill.	لكل فولة كمال	Colloquial
as busy as a bee	يعمل كأنحلة	مُزَيَّيْ أمّ العروس means <i>busy but achieving little</i> , so check the nuance

Institutions and titles

the Home Office (UK)	وزارة الداخلية البريطانية
the Chancellor of the Exchequer (UK)	وزير المالية البريطاني
the Secretary of the Treasury (US)	وزير الخزانة الأمريكي
the Secretary of State (US)	وزير الخارجية الأمريكي
a sheriff (US)	مأمور الشرطة في المقاطعة
the House managers (US impeachment trial)	أعضاء مجلس النواب المكلفون بالادعاء
watchdog press · lapdog press	الصحافة الرقابية · الصحافة الموالية للسلطة

When the climate changes the meaning

In English, warmth is comforting. In the Arab world, where the heat is harsh, relief is *cold*.

It warmed my heart. → أثلجَ صدري

A literal أَدْفَأَ قَلْبِي ❌ misses the effect. The TL image is reversed so that the *feeling* stays the same.

CASE STUDY · SHAKESPEARE, SONNET 18

*Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more
temperate...*

Literal

أَشْبَهَكَ بِيَوْمٍ مِنْ أَيَّامِ
الصَّيْفِ؟

Approximated

أَشْبَهَكَ بِيَوْمٍ رِبِيعِيٍّ؟

An English summer is mild and lovely, but a Gulf summer is scorching. Many translators move the image to spring.

Formulaic expressions

العبارات الجاهزة

Greetings, condolences and religious formulas are fixed in both cultures. Translate them with the TL formula used in the *same situation*, never word for word.

English	العربية	Situation
I'm so sorry for your loss.	عَظَّمَ اللَّهُ أَجْرَكُمْ / الْبَقَاءُ لِلَّهِ	Condolence
We're fine, thank you.	بِخَيْرٍ، الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ	Reply to "How are you?"
Calm down, let it go.	وَحَدِّدُوا لِلَّهِ، وَالْمَسَاحُ كَرِيمٌ	Colloquial
Welcome! It's an honour to have you.	أَهْلًا وَسَهْلًا، شَرَّفْتُمُونَا	Hospitality
Many happy returns!	عَسَاكُمْ مِنْ عَوَادِهِ	Gulf festive greeting

العربية	English	Situation
إِنْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ	God willing · I hope so	Future plans
اللَّهُ يَعْطِيكَ الْعَافِيَةَ	Thank you for all your hard work.	Thanks for effort
تَقَبَّلَ اللَّهُ	May God accept it (your prayers or fasting).	After worship

PROVERBS WITH READY EQUIVALENTS AR → EN

عَصْفُورٌ فِي الْيَدِ خَيْرٌ مِنْ عَشْرَةِ عَلَى الشَّجَرَةِ	A bird in the hand is worth two in the bush.
فِي التَّأَنِّي السَّلَامَةُ وَفِي الْعَجَلَةِ النَّدَامَةُ	Haste makes waste.
الْوَقْتُ كَالسَّيْفِ إِنْ لَمْ تَقْطَعْهُ قَطَعَكَ	Time and tide wait for no man.

- **Guild tip.** Formulas also have a register. اَتَىَّ اللَّهُ! can render an exasperated *What on earth are you saying?* But it is religious and reproachful in tone, so check that it suits the speaker and the scene.

10 Descriptive translation and lexical creation

الترجمة الوصفية والنحت المعجمي

KEY TERMS

Descriptive translation

الترجمة الوصفية / الشرحية

Concept

مفهوم

Semantic density

الكثافة الدلالية

مفاهيم أساسية

An explanatory strategy: the SL item is paraphrased in the TL by describing its concept. It is a last resort.

A complex meaning, often cultural, religious or technical, that a single word stands for.

A lot of meaning packed into one word. The denser the word, the more description it needs.

Two steps

- 1 **Transliterate** the SL word: زكاة → *zakat*.
- 2 **Describe** its meaning in the TL, either in brackets after the word or in a footnote.

Culture-bound Arabic terms

AR → EN

الزكاة	<i>zakat</i> : obligatory almsgiving in Islam, paid yearly on wealth above a set threshold
التيمم	<i>tayammum</i> : dry ablution with clean earth when water is unavailable
البسملة	<i>the basmala</i> : saying "In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful"
الحوقلة	<i>the hawqala</i> : saying "There is no power nor strength except through God"
العدة	<i>'idda</i> : the waiting period a woman observes after divorce or widowhood before remarrying
الاستتابة	<i>istitaba</i> : a formal call to repent, issued before a legal penalty is applied
العتوة	<i>'atwa</i> : a temporary truce under tribal customary law (Jordan and the Levant)
الديوانية	<i>diwaniya</i> : a regular Kuwaiti social gathering held in a home's reception hall

English culture-bound terms

EN → AR

Ali has been sectioned. (UK)

أودع عليٌّ مستشفى للأمراض النفسية قسراً بموجب قانون الصحة النفسية

psychology · psychiatry

علم النفس · الطب النفسي

yin and yang

الين واليانغ (مفهوم صيني عن قوتين متضادتين متكاملتين)

Lexical creation

النحت المعجمي / التوليد

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Lexical creation (coinage)

The deliberate coining of new words or expressions in the TL for culture-specific, technical or conceptual SL items that have no direct equivalent, because of a **lexical gap** in the TL.

Lexicalisation التعجم

The point at which a coinage is accepted and enters the dictionary.

Arabicisation التعريب

Adapting a borrowed word to Arabic sounds and morphology, as with رَقْنَة for *digitisation*.

Concepts rooted in religion, politics, technology or culture often have no ready TL word. In those cases, the translator becomes a **coiner** of new lexical items.

Type	How it works	Examples
Neologism	A new word, often built from an Arabic root.	<i>blog</i> → مدوّنة · <i>digitisation</i> → رقّنة
Calque (loan translation)	Morpheme-by-morpheme translation: a modified literal translation.	<i>smartphone</i> → الهاتف الذكي · <i>global warming</i> → الاحترار العالمي · <i>shadow government</i> → حكومة الظل
Transliteration	A phonetic borrowing, with a short definition the first time it appears.	<i>radio</i> → راديو · <i>internet</i> → إنترنت
Hybrid	Translation mixed with transliteration.	<i>cybersecurity</i> → الأمن السيبراني
Explanation	A short descriptive phrase that settles into use.	<i>jet lag</i> → إرهاق السفر الجوي · <i>co-wife</i> → الضرة

New terms in the news

<i>greenwashing</i>	التضليل البيئي	When companies falsely present their products as eco-friendly
<i>cancel culture</i>	ثقافة الإلغاء	Publicly withdrawing support from someone as a sanction
<i>product cannibalisation</i>	تزاحم المنتجات	A firm's new product takes sales from its own older one. The literal أكل لحوم البشر is absurd.
<i>the greenhouse effect</i>	الاحتباس الحراري	An established term
<i>a columnist · peace talks</i>	كاتب عمود · محادثات السلام	
<i>Valentine's Day · Thanksgiving</i>	عيد الحب · عيد الشكر	Culture-specific festivals

- **Guild tip.** Before coining, **search** the Arabic language academies, UNTERM and Arabterm (Ch. 11–12). An accepted term almost always beats a new invention.

11 Terminology management

إدارة المصطلحات وأدلة المصطلحات

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Term مصطلح	A word or expression that names a concept within a specialised field. Examples are <i>provided that</i> in law and <i>greenhouse effect</i> in science.
Terminology علم المصطلح	The set of terms in a field, and the discipline that studies them. Every field, and every branch of linguistics, has its own terms.
Termbase قاعدة المصطلحات	A structured database of term records, usually one record per concept.
Terminology guide دليل المصطلحات	A project or client document that lists approved, admitted and forbidden terms, together with style rules.

Five principles

- 1 **One concept, one entry.** Organise by concept, not by word.
- 2 **One term per concept** throughout a text. Never vary a term for style.
- 3 **Cite a source** for every term, and record its context.
- 4 **Mark the status** of each term: preferred, admitted or deprecated.
- 5 **Share and update** the list, so the whole team uses the same terms.

A sample term record

Term record #041 · Environment

EN term	greenwashing
AR term	التضليل البيئي preferred
Also seen	الغسل الأخضر admitted
Definition	Misleading claims that a product or company is environmentally friendly
Context	<i>The firm was accused of greenwashing.</i>
Source	Checked in UNTERM and in Arabic press usage
Date / by	2026-09 · Guild Translation Team

The terminology workflow



Where to find approved Arabic terms

UNTERM (United Nations) · **WIPO Pearl** (science and technology) · **Arabterm** (ALECSO and GIZ, technical fields) · the lexicons of the **Arabic language academies** in Cairo, Damascus and Amman · your client's own glossaries and style guide.

Tools: a shared spreadsheet is enough to begin. Termbases in CAT tools such as Trados MultiTerm or memoQ flag terms as you type, and the TBX format lets termbases move between tools.

12 Printed and digital dictionaries

المعاجم المطبوعة والرقمية

PART III • TOOLS

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Monolingual dictionary معجم أحادي اللغة	Defines words in the same language. Use it to <i>confirm</i> meaning and usage.
Bilingual dictionary معجم ثنائي اللغة	Gives equivalents in another language. Use it to <i>find</i> candidate equivalents.
Specialised dictionary معجم متخصص	Covers one field, such as law or medicine.
Corpus مدونة نصية	A large collection of real texts that shows how words are actually used.

Resource	Type	Best for
Printed		
Al-Mawrid, M. Baalbaki (EN-AR) and R. Baalbaki (AR-EN)	Bilingual	General vocabulary in both directions
Hans Wehr, <i>A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic</i>	AR-EN	Arabic organised by root; MSA usage
Al-Mu'jam al-Wasīṭ: Lisān al-'Arab	Arabic mono.	Modern usage (Cairo Academy); classical and poetic vocabulary (Ibn Manzūr)
Oxford Advanced Learner's · Oxford Collocations Dictionary	English mono.	English definitions and natural word partners
Faruqi's Law Dictionary · Hitti's Medical Dictionary	Specialised	Legal and medical terms, EN-AR
Digital		
Almaany المعاني · Reverso Context	Online	Quick lookups and phrases in real translated sentences. Always verify.
UNTERM · WIPO Pearl · Arabterm	Termbases	Official and technical terms (Ch. 11)
Doha Historical Dictionary of Arabic	Historical	The history of Arabic words
UN Parallel Corpus · Sketch Engine	Corpora	Frequency and collocation evidence

The triangulation method

- 1 Find candidate equivalents in a **bilingual** dictionary.
- 2 Confirm each one in a **TL monolingual** dictionary.
- 3 Check real usage in a **corpus** or parallel text.
- 4 Check a **specialised** source, then record the term.

EXAMPLE •

FAST COLOUR

Bilingual: صائم، ثابت

Monolingual: ثابت = does not fade

Corpus: ألوان ثابتة in textile texts

Decision: لون ثابت

13 Machine translation and AI

الترجمة الآلية والذكاء الاصطناعي

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Machine translation الترجمة الآلية

Translation produced automatically by software.

NMT الترجمة الآلية العصبية

Neural MT: a neural network trained on millions of human translations predicts the TT. It is the basis of most modern MT engines.

LLM النموذج اللغوي الكبيرة

A large language model: general AI systems (chat assistants) that can translate, rewrite and explain on instruction.

CAT tool • TM أدوات الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب • ذاكرة الترجمة

Software that stores your past translations (TM) and terms (TB) so you can reuse them. It supports the translator rather than replacing them.

Post-editing التحرير اللاحق

A human editing MT output to reach an agreed level of quality (ISO 18587).

Hallucination المحلوسة

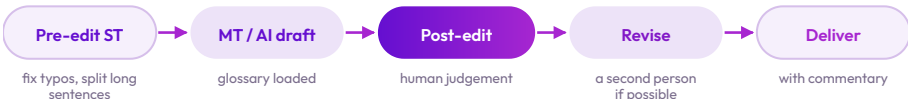
AI output that is fluent but not supported by the ST: added facts, invented names, missing negations.

From rules to neural networks

A SHORT HISTORY OF MT



Where MT fits in a professional workflow



MT IS USEFUL FOR...

- getting the gist and first drafts of repetitive, informative texts
- large volumes on a tight deadline
- brainstorming alternative phrasings

MT IS RISKY FOR...

- legal, medical and religious texts
- poetry, humour, advertising and idioms
- confidential or personal material

Typical English–Arabic MT errors

Error	Machine output	Human fix
Literal idiom	<i>It's raining cats and dogs</i> → إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً ✗	تمطر بغزارة
Default masculine	<i>The doctor said she...</i> → ... قال الطبيب ✗	قالت الطبيبة...
Calqued word order	الحكومة أعلنت أمس أن... ✗	أعلنت الحكومة أمس أن...
Wrong collocation	<i>pay attention</i> → ادفع الانتباه ✗	انتبه / أعر انتباهك
Ambiguity with no diacritics (AR → EN)	علم → <i>flag? knowledge? he knew? he taught?</i>	Read the co-text
Names and numbers	Inconsistent spellings (ترامب / ترامب) and mixed digits (١٢ / 12)	Follow the style guide
Hallucination / omission	A dropped “not”, or an added claim	Compare segment by segment

Post-editing: two levels (ISO 18587)

LIGHT POST-EDITING

The TT must be **accurate and understandable**, but style can be imperfect. It suits internal use or a quick gist.

FULL POST-EDITING

The TT must reach **publishable quality**, comparable to human translation. It suits anything public, such as the press, clients and print.

Using AI responsibly

- **Confidentiality first.** Never paste a client's confidential text into a public MT or AI tool without permission.
- **Disclose** the use of MT or AI to your client, and follow any rules they set.
- **You are responsible** for every word you deliver, whatever tool produced the draft.
- **Instruct precisely:** give the audience, the register, the variety of Arabic and your glossary.
- **Verify everything**, especially terms, names, numbers and negations.
- **Keep your skills sharp.** Post-editing needs a translator's judgement, and assessing translation quality is now a core professional skill.

A WELL-WRITTEN AI INSTRUCTION

Translate the press release below from English into Modern Standard Arabic for readers in the Gulf. Use a formal news register and verb-first sentences. Use these terms: greenwashing = التلطيّل البيئي; Home Office = وزارة الداخلية. Do not add, omit or summarise anything. List any ambiguous phrases separately.

- **Guild tip.** Treat MT as a very fast, very confident intern. It is often useful, sometimes brilliant, and never to be trusted without checking.

PART IV · PRACTICE · PHASE 1: ANALYSE

14 Text analysis and genres

تحليل النصوص وأجناسها

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Text النص

Any stretch of language that communicates: a word, a sentence, a paragraph or a book.

Text analysis تحليل النص

Breaking a text down and processing it before translation, to identify its features, background and problems.

Genre الجنس النصي

A conventional type of text with recognisable features, such as a news report, a contract or a poem.

Tone النبرة

The writer's attitude: neutral, critical, persuasive, ironic and so on.

Why analyse first?

- Every new reading brings out new ideas and problems.
- It identifies the **field, genre, tone, style, time and purpose** of the text.
- It identifies the **audience** of both the ST and the TT.
- It shows whether you are ready, or need more resources.
- It lets you pick your strategies in advance.
- It gives you a **mental draft** of the translation, so you work faster.

ANALYSIS

التحليل

Identifies the **features, background and main ideas** of the text: who wrote it, for whom, how and why.

SUMMARY

التلخيص

Gives only the facts of what the text is about. **Do not summarise or paraphrase when asked to analyse.**

Worked example: a KUNA news report

Field	Political news, with Kuwait and Australia as the topic.
Author / publisher	KUNA (Kuwait News Agency), the state news agency. Follow its terminology and house style.
Audience	Readers interested in Kuwait and the Middle East.
Tone and style	Straightforward and formal. Use formal language and avoid short forms.
Word choice	Watch for connotation, e.g. <i>government rents</i> , and for specialised terms.
Strategy	Mostly literal and communicative, since the text has no metaphors. Keep the headline short , with no additions.

- **Guid tip.** Your analysis and your translation must agree. If the analysis calls the tone formal, a single colloquial word in your TT will be noticed. Flag every problem in the analysis, then solve it in the translation.

The main genres, with one example each

Genre	Key features	Example
News الخبر الصحفي	Facts first, short headlines, reported speech	<i>Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.</i> ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
Legal القانوني	Precision, fixed formulas, <i>shall</i> , doublets	<i>This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.</i> تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.
Poetry الشعر	Metre, rhyme, imagery, compression	<i>الليل والليل والبيداء تعرفني . والسيف والرمح والقرطاس والقلم</i> (al-Mutanabbi) <i>The horses, the night and the desert know me, as do the sword, the spear, the parchment and the pen.</i>
Religious and cultural الديني والثقافي	Fixed formulas, sacred terms, approved translations	رمضان كريم <i>Ramadan Kareem / Wishing you a blessed Ramadan</i>
Medical الطبي	Latin and Greek terms, passive voice, zero ambiguity	<i>The patient presented with acute abdominal pain.</i> راجع المريض وهو يشكو من ألم حاد في البطن.
Technical التقني	Imperatives, consistent terms, numbered steps	<i>Press and hold the power button for five seconds.</i> اضغط مطولاً على زر التشغيل لمدة خمس ثوانٍ.
Political and diplomatic السياسي	Careful, loaded vocabulary and set phrases	<i>The two sides held frank and constructive talks.</i> أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبناءة.
Advertising الإعلاني	Persuasion, rhythm, wordplay, transcreation	<i>Save more. Smile more.</i> وفر أكثر... وابسم أكثر! (the parallelism is kept)
Academic الأكاديمي	Hedging, citations, formal register	<i>This study examines the role of...</i> تناول هذه الدراسة دور...

How to write a comprehensive analysis

- 1 **Identify** the text type, its purpose and its genre, e.g. an informative news report.
- 2 **Place it:** author or speaker, publisher, date and place, and the ST and TT audiences.
- 3 **Describe it:** field, tone, style, register and length.
- 4 **List the problems:** terms, idioms, culture-specific items and ideologically loaded words.
- 5 **Choose strategies** for each problem, and note the resources you will need.

HEADLINES AND TITLES

Keep them as short as possible and never add information. Arabic headlines prefer the present tense.

Kuwait, Australia → الكويت وأستراليا
sign trade deal توقعان اتفاقية تجارية

HYBRID TEXTS

A single text can mix genres, for example a news report that quotes a Qur'anic verse and a legal clause. Treat each part by the rules of its own genre, and use an established translation for the verse.

Be a good critic. Build your **own analysis model** from Checklist 1 (p. 33) and train it on every text. It is the fastest way to improve translation quality and proficiency.

15

PART IV · PRACTICE · CRITICAL DISCOURSE ANALYSIS

Fairclough's relational model

التحليل النقدي للخطاب: نموذج فيركلف العلائقي

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Discourse الخطاب

Language in use, seen as a form of social practice.

CDA التحليل النقدي للخطاب

An approach that studies how language produces, keeps up or resists **power and ideology**.

Ideology الأيديولوجيا

A set of beliefs and values that shapes how events are represented.

Intertextuality التناص

The way a text draws on and echoes other texts.

3 · SOCIAL PRACTICE

2 · DISCURSIVE PRACTICE

1 · TEXT

description

interpretation: production · distribution · consumption

explanation: ideology · power · institutions

Fairclough (1989, 1992) analyses every text in **three nested dimensions**. He later calls this a *dialectical-relational* approach (Fairclough 2009), because text, discursive practice and society constantly shape one another.

A translation is itself a discursive practice. Your choices can **reproduce or neutralise** the ideology of the ST.

Ideology in translators' choices

regime · government

نظام · حكومة

The first delegitimises

militants · terrorists · fighters

مسلمون · إرهابيون · مقاتلون

Each takes a stance

Protesters were killed. (no agent)

قتل متظاهرون

The passive hides who did it

Checklist · Fairclough for translators

1 · TEXT

- ☐ Which words carry evaluation or connotation?
- ☐ Who is the agent, and who is hidden by the passive?
- ☐ Which metaphors frame the issue?

2 · DISCURSIVE PRACTICE

- ☐ Who produced the text, for which outlet?
- ☐ Which other texts does it quote or echo?

3 · SOCIAL PRACTICE

- ☐ Whose interests does the text serve?
- ☐ What ideology or power relation does it reflect?

YOUR TRANSLATION

- ☐ Have I kept, softened or intensified the ST's stance, and why?
- ☐ Does my choice follow the client's policy?
- ☐ Have I flagged loaded terms in the commentary?

PART IV · PRACTICE · PHASE 3: COMMENT

16 Translation commentary

التعليق على الترجمة وكتابة الملاحظات

KEY TERMS

Translation commentary

التعليق على الترجمة

Translation criticism

نقد الترجمة

A reflective text in which the translator explains the problems met in a translation and **justifies** the solutions chosen.

Evaluating a translation, your own or someone else's, against the ST and the brief.

مفاهيم أساسية

Structure

Part one: reflect on your analysis. Cover the text type, audience, purpose and the main problems you expected.

Part two: reflect on your translation. For each problem, give the **problem**, **then the solution**, **then the justification**, with examples from the ST and TT.

Useful phrases

The ST features...

To preserve the..., the translator opted for...

A functional equivalent was preferred over a formal one because...

This detail was omitted because it is irrelevant to the target audience.

The term was verified in UNTERM and *Al-Mawrid*.

The loaded term X was rendered as Y, following the client's style guide.

Rules

- Write in the **third person**: “*The translator faced...*”
- **Always quote examples** from the ST and TT.
- **Name** the procedure or strategy (Ch. 7–8).
- Mention the **dictionaries and resources** you used.
- Answer the WH questions: *what* was the problem, *why* did it arise, *how* was it solved, and with *what* effect?

A model commentary paragraph

The ST describes the agreement as having “remained a dead letter”. A formal rendering, حرفاً ميتاً, would have kept the image but puzzled Arab readers. The translator therefore chose the functional equivalent حرفاً على ورق, an established Arabic idiom that does the same job and suits the formal register of the news report. The choice was checked against Arabic press usage.

Critiquing someone else's translation

Compare the ST and TT segment by segment. Note every **shift** (additions, omissions, changes of meaning or register), then judge the TT against five criteria: **accuracy · terminology · fluency · style · fitness for the brief**. Separate real errors from legitimate preferences.

17

Interlingual risk assessment

مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر بين اللغتين

KEY TERMS

مفاهيم أساسية

Risk الخطر

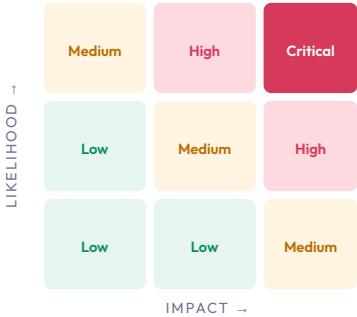
The chance that a translation decision causes harm, multiplied by how serious that harm would be (Pym 2015).

Likelihood · Impact

How likely an error is · how much damage it would do to the client, the reader or you.

Mitigation التخفيف

An action that lowers the risk, such as research, a second reviewer, back-translation or a note to the client.



How to use it. During revision, list the risky items in your TT and place each one in the grid.

- **Critical / High** Research it again, get a second reviewer, and flag it to the client.
- **Medium** Check it against a reliable source.
- **Low** Accept it, and note it if relevant.

Risk	Example	L × I	Mitigation
Politically loaded name	<i>Persian Gulf</i> / الخليج العربي	H × H	Client style guide; flag it
Legal or medical term	<i>shall; twice daily vs every 12 hours</i>	M × H	Specialised dictionary; second reviewer
Numbers, dates, units	Hijri or Gregorian dates; Arabic or Western digits; the decimal mark	M × H	Check every figure against the ST
Religious text	Quoting a Qur'anic verse	M × H	Use an established translation and cite it
Dropped negation	<i>not</i> lost in MT output	L × H	Segment-by-segment comparison
Gender and address	<i>you, the doctor</i>	H × M	Establish the referent from context
False friend	<i>sensible</i> is not حَسَّاس but معقول	M × M	Monolingual check
Register mismatch	Dialect in a formal report	M × M	Re-read against the brief
Confidential data	A client file pasted into public AI	M × H	Approved or offline tools only

● ● ● TEAR-OUT TOOLS

Practical checklists

قوائم التحقق العملية

• CHECKLIST 1 · BEFORE YOU TRANSLATE · ANALYSIS

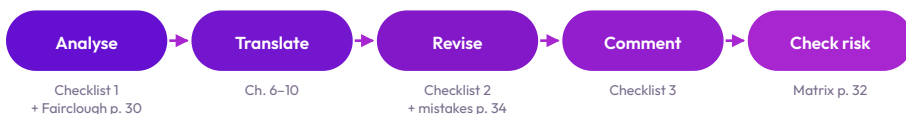
- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Client and brief: who asked, and why? | ☐ Tone and style of writing |
| ☐ Purpose of the TT: to inform, persuade, instruct or bind? | ☐ Terms highlighted and researched |
| ☐ Audience of the ST and of the TT | ☐ Idioms, metaphors and culture-specific items marked |
| ☐ Author / speaker and publisher | ☐ Loaded words noted (Ch. 15) |
| ☐ Field and genre | ☐ Strategies chosen; resources ready |

• CHECKLIST 2 · AFTER YOU TRANSLATE · REVISION AND QUALITY

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Nothing omitted or added without a reason | ☐ Arabic: verb-first where natural; hamza, /ة/ and /ي/ correct |
| ☐ Meaning preserved, including every negation | ☐ English: articles, tenses and capitals correct |
| ☐ Terms consistent with the glossary | ☐ Punctuation suited to the TL (؟ ؛ ،) |
| ☐ Names, numbers, dates and units checked | ☐ Titles and captions translated |
| ☐ Collocations natural in the TL | ☐ TT read once without the ST |

• CHECKLIST 3 · COMMENTARY AND RISK

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Part one reflects on the analysis | ☐ Written in the third person |
| ☐ Part two covers each problem, its solution and the justification | ☐ Resources and dictionaries cited |
| ☐ Examples quoted from the ST and TT | ☐ High-risk items flagged (Ch. 17) |
| ☐ Procedures and strategies named | ☐ MT or AI use disclosed, if any |



The full cycle, with the checklist that goes with each step

● ● ● QUICK REFERENCE

Common grammatical and stylistic mistakes

أخطاء نحوية وأسلوبية شائعة

In Arabic translations

EN → AR

Mistake	X	✓
Subject-first by default	الحكومة أعلنت...	أعلنت الحكومة...
Overusing قام بـ	قام الوزير بزيارة...	زار الوزير...
Calqued passive with من قبل	تم افتتاح المعرض من قبل الوزير	افتتح الوزير المعرض
Number and gender (3-10)	ثلاث طلاب	ثلاثة طلاب
Accusative after كان and its sisters	أصبح الجو بارد	أصبح الجو بارداً
Hamza, ة، هـ، ي	إنشاء · مدرسه · إلى	إنشاء · مدرسة · إلى
English punctuation	نعم، شكراً؟	نعم، شكراً؟
Overusing حيث as a connector	...، حيث قال الوزير إن...	... وقال الوزير إن...
Pronoun agreement	المدينة وسكانه	المدينة وسكانها
Calqued letter openings	عزيزي السيد أحمد (formal)	حضرة السيد أحمد المحترم

In English translations

AR → EN

Mistake	X	✓
Run-on sentences linked by <i>and</i>	...and he said and he added and...	Split them with full stops.
Kept synonym pairs	brave and daring and valiant	exceptionally brave
Generic <i>the</i>	<i>The life is beautiful.</i> (الحياة)	<i>Life is beautiful.</i>
Missing <i>to be</i>	<i>He in the office.</i>	<i>He is in the office.</i>
Preposition calques	<i>married from her</i> (تزوج منها)	<i>married her</i>
Past simple for present perfect	<i>I lived here since 2010.</i>	<i>I have lived here since 2010.</i>
Titles not capitalised	<i>the minister of health</i>	<i>the Minister of Health</i>
Inconsistent transliteration	<i>Mohammed / Muhammad / Mohamad</i>	One system throughout

- **Why a separate section?** These mistakes cut across every chapter, so they are gathered here as a revision tool. Use them with Checklist 2 (p. 33).

● ● ● PUT IT ALL TOGETHER

Exercises at three levels

تمارين تطبيقية بثلاثة مستويات

The levels grow in length: sentences, then paragraphs, then full texts. Together they cover the main theories and genres in this handbook. Practice texts marked ♦ were written for this handbook in an authentic news register. In workshops, add a current news article on the same topic.

1 Sentences مستوى الجُمْل

Translate each sentence, and name the concept or strategy you used.

EN → AR

- 1 She paid a visit to her grandmother. Ch. 4
- 2 The agreement has remained a dead letter. Ch. 5
- 3 He is a heavy smoker. Ch. 7
- 4 It's raining cats and dogs. Ch. 4
- 5 The Home Secretary visited Kuwait yesterday. Ch. 9
- 6 This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait. Ch. 14

AR → EN

- 7 رجع بخفي حنين. Ch. 4
- 8 أثلج الخبر صدري. Ch. 9
- 9 هو شجاع مغوار. Ch. 8
- 10 تعدّ الديوانية جزءاً أساسياً من الحياة الاجتماعية في الكويت. Ch. 10
- 11 يساورني القلق بشأن النتائج. Ch. 4
- 12 اضغط مطولاً على زر التشغيل. (Back-translate your answer.) Ch. 6

2 Paragraphs مستوى الفقرة

Complete Checklist 1 first, then translate, then write three commentary sentences.

2A • NEWS ♦ EN → AR

The city's central library will extend its opening hours during the summer holiday, officials announced on Sunday. The library, which houses more than 200,000 titles, will stay open until 10 p.m. on weekdays. The move aims to encourage young people to read, officials said, adding that free workshops on creative writing and translation will also be held.

2B • HUMAN RIGHTS TEXT (AUTHENTIC) EN → AR

All human beings are born free and equal in dignity and rights. They are endowed with reason and conscience and should act towards one another in a spirit of brotherhood.

Source • Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948), Article 1. Afterwards, compare your version with the official UN Arabic text.

2C • POETRY AR – EN

الخليلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني . والسيفُ والرمحُ والقرطاسُ والقلمُ

Source • al-Mutanabbi (d. 965), *Dīwān*. Keep the list rhythm. What happens to القُرطاسُ?

2D • POETRY EN – AR

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?

Thou art more lovely and more temperate:

Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,

And summer's lease hath all too short a date.

Source • Shakespeare, Sonnet 18 (1609), lines 1–4. Decide: summer or spring? Justify your choice (Ch. 9).

QUICK CHECK • WHICH PROCEDURE? (CH. 7)

1 television → تلفزيون • 2 honeymoon → شهر العسل • 3 before leaving → قبل أن يغادر • 4 Keep your chin up. → لا تبتئس • 5 It is not unlikely. → من المرجح • 6 baseball (children's story) → كرة القدم

3 Full texts مستوى النص الكامل

Complete the full cycle: **analyse** (Checklist 1 and the Fairclough checklist), **translate**, **revise** (Checklist 2), write a 250-word commentary (Checklist 3), and **place three items** in the risk matrix.

3A • NEWS FEATURE ♦ EN – AR

Health officials have urged residents to stay indoors between 11 a.m. and 4 p.m. as temperatures are expected to top 50°C this week. “Heatstroke is not something to take lightly,” a Ministry of Health spokesperson said, advising people to drink plenty of water and to check on elderly neighbours. Outdoor workers are most at risk. Under existing regulations, outdoor work is banned during the hottest hours of the day in summer, and companies that break the rules face fines. Meanwhile, shopping malls are expected to be packed as families seek relief from the heat, with some staying open until midnight.

3B • CULTURAL NEWS ♦ AR – EN

احتفلت الجمعية الثقافية مساء أمس بتكريم نخبة من المترجمين الشباب، وذلك في أمسية حضرها لفيف من الأدباء والأكاديميين. وأكد رئيس الجمعية في كلمته أن الترجمة جسر يصل الشعوب بعضها ببعض، مشيراً إلى أن العناية بالمترجمين الشباب واجب لا ترف. واختتمت الأمسية بقراءات شعرية مترجمة، وسط أجواء سادها الود والتقدير.

Workshop leaders: pair students so that one translates and the other analyses, then swap. Compare the commentaries, not just the translations.

● ● ● MODEL ANSWERS AND EXPLANATIONS

Answer key

الإجابات النموذجية مع الشرح

These are **model** answers, not the only correct ones. Any rendering that is accurate, natural and fits the brief is acceptable.

Level 1

1	زارت جدّتها.	Collocation: the verb زار, not دفعت زيارة .
2	ظَلَّت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.	A functional equivalent (Farghal).
3	يدخّن بشراة.	Transposition: adjective + noun becomes verb + adverbial.
4	تمطر بغزارة / كأفواه القرب.	An idiom never goes word for word.
5	زار وزير الداخلية البريطاني الكويت أمس.	Cultural approximation of a title; verb-first.
6	تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.	Legal <i>shall</i> becomes the Arabic present tense, not سوف .
7	He came back empty-handed.	A proverb rendered by equivalence.
8	The news warmed my heart.	The image is reversed, from cold to warm (Ch. 9).
9	He is exceptionally brave.	Omission of the synonym pair.
10	The diwaniya, a regular gathering held in a home's reception hall, is central to social life in Kuwait.	Borrowing + description.
11	I am growing worried about the results.	An Arabic collocation made natural in English.
12	Press and hold the power button.	Technical imperative; مطوّلاً becomes <i>hold</i> .

Quick check: 1 borrowing · 2 calque · 3 transposition · 4 equivalence · 5 modulation · 6 adaptation

Level 2a · model

أعلن مسؤولون يوم الأحد أنّ المكتبة المركزية في المدينة ستمدّد ساعات عملها خلال العطلة الصيفية، إذ ستظلّ المكتبة، التي تضمّ أكثر من 200 ألف عنوان، مفتوحةً حتى العاشرة مساءً في أيام العمل. وأوضح المسؤولون أنّ هذه الخطوة تهدف إلى تشجيع الشباب على القراءة، مضيفين أنّه ستُعقد أيضاً ورش عمل مجانية في الكتابة الإبداعية والترجمة.

Points: the reporting clause moves to the front; the verb comes first; *adding that* becomes أنّ مضيفين أنّ; *stay open* becomes تظلّ مفتوحةً.

Level 3b · model

Last night, the Cultural Society honoured a group of outstanding young translators at an evening attended by writers and academics. In his speech, the society's president described translation as a bridge between peoples, adding that caring for young translators is a duty, not a luxury. The evening closed with readings of translated poetry in a warm, appreciative atmosphere.

Points: the long sentence is split; لقيف من becomes *attended by*; the pair الودّ والتقدير becomes one phrase; the metaphor جسر is kept because the image is shared.

Glossary of terms

مسرد المصطلحات

Every key term, with its Arabic equivalent and the page where it is **defined and illustrated**.

Adaptation	التكييف	14, 17	Intersemiotic translation	الترجمة بين العلامات	5
Addition / explicitation	الإضافة	18	Intertextuality	النصّ	30
Approximation	التقريب	20	Intralingual translation	الترجمة ضمن اللغة	5
Arabisation	التعريب	23	Lexical creation	النحت المعجمي	23
Back-translation	الترجمة العكسية	15	Lexicalisation	التعجيم	23
Borrowing	الاقتراض	16	Literal translation	الترجمة الحرفية	15, 16
Calque	النسخ	16, 23	LLM	النموذج اللغوي الكبير	26
CAT tool	أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب	26	Localisation	التوطين	15
Collocation	اتلازم اللفظي	11	Macro context	السياق الخارجي	10
Communication	التواصل	5	Machine translation (MT)	الترجمة الآلية	26
Communicative translation	الترجمة التواصلية	14	Meaning	المعنى	9
Compensation	التعويض	18	Metaphor	الاستعارة	19
Concept	المفهوم	22	Method	المنهج	14, 17
Connotation	المعنى الإيحائي	9	Mitigation	التخفيف	32
Context	السياق	10	Modulation	التحوير	17
Co-text (micro context)	السياق النصي	10	Neologism	اللفظ المستحدث	23
Corpus	المجموعة النصية	25	NMT	الترجمة الآلية العصبية	26
CDA	التحليل النقدي للخطاب	30	Oblique translation	الترجمة غير المباشرة	16
Cultural approximation	التقريب الثقافي	20	Omission	الحذف	18
Cultural substitution	الإبدال الثقافي	18	Polysemy	تعدد المعنى	10
Culture-specific item	العنصر الثقافي الخاص	20	Post-editing	التحرير اللاحق	27
Denotation	المعنى الإشاري	9	Procedure	الإجراء	16
Derivational language	اللغة الاشتقاقية	7	Proverb	المثل	12
Descriptive translation	الترجمة الوصفية	22	Register	المستوى اللغوي	7
Diglossia	الازدواجية اللغوية	7	Risk	الخطر	32
Direct translation	الترجمة المباشرة	16	Semantic density	الكثافة الدلالية	22
Discourse	الخطاب	30	Semantic translation	الترجمة الدلالية	14
Domestication	التوطين	18	Speaker meaning	قصد المتكلم	10
Dynamic equivalence	التكافؤ الدينامي	13	Sight translation	الترجمة المنظورة	15
Equivalence	التكافؤ	13	Simile	التشبيه	19
Equivalence (procedure)	التكافؤ	17	Strategy	الاستراتيجية	18
Figurative language	اللغة المجازية	19	Superordinate	اللفظ الأعم	18
Foreignisation	التعريب	18	Term	المصطلح	24
Form	البناء	9	Termbase	قاعدة المصطلحات	24
Formal equivalence	التكافؤ الشكلي	13	Terminology guide	دليل المصطلحات	24
Free translation	الترجمة الحرة	15	Text analysis	تحليل النص	28
Functional equivalence	التكافؤ الوظيفي	13	Tone	النبرة	28
Genre	الجنس النصي	28	Transcreation	الترجمة الإبداعية	15
Hallucination	الهلوسة	26	Translation	الترجمة التحريرية	5
Homonymy	المشترك اللفظي	10	Translation brief	موجز الترجمة	4
Ideational equivalence	التكافؤ الفكري	13	Translation commentary	التعليق على الترجمة	31
Ideology	الأيدولوجيا	30	Translation memory (TM)	ذاكرة الترجمة	26
Idiom	التعبير الاصطلاحي	12	Translation Studies	علم الترجمة	5
Interlingual translation	الترجمة بين لغتين	5	Transliteration	النقل الصوتي	23
Interpretation	الترجمة الشفهية	5, 15	Transposition	الإبدال	17

● ● ● BACK MATTER

References

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